MGMTEX 298-E – AI AGENTS FOR MANAGERS

Spring 2026 – 2 Units

Course Syllabus

REVISED 2/4/2026

Teaching Team Information

Faculty of Record: Professor Gregor Schubert
Email: gregor.schubert@anderson.ucla.edu
Office location: C-406
Office hours: By appointment

Course Assistant: Tanish Dhariyal, tanish.dhariyal.2027@anderson.ucla.edu

Office hours: By appointment

Course meeting times and location

Course Day & Time: This class meets 7:10pm-10:00pm on Wednesdays during the **first five weeks of the Spring 2026 term.** Please see Course Outline for specific dates.
Course Location: Cornell Hall, D301
Course Site: https://bruinlearn.ucla.edu/courses/226716

Pre-requisites/Co-requisites

None.

Course Description

Catalog Description

This course prepares future business leaders to leverage AI Agents in the workplace. Students learn to design, implement, and manage AI systems powered by Large Language Models (LLMs) that can transform business operations. Through real-world case studies, hands-on exercises (no coding experience required), and guest experts, both technical and non-technical students will develop practical skills to lead AI-enhanced teams and workflows.

Expanded Description

Master AI Tools That Are Reshaping Business Leadership. As companies across all industries transform into 'AI-first' organizations, the ability to strategically implement and manage AI-based processes has become essential for today's business leaders. This course empowers you to confidently lead in this new landscape. Knowing how to design and manage AI-based processes is no longer the specialized domain of "technical" employees but becoming a baseline requirement for all employees and business leaders to succeed in the workplace.

A key role in this transformation is played by "AI Agents" – systems that combine large language model (LLM) capabilities with other business processes to automate tasks and increase human productivity. This course is designed to help any stakeholders in businesses design and work with these systems.

What You'll Learn:

- Design and implement AI Agents – systems that apply language model (LLM) capabilities in business processes – that automate routine tasks and enhance team productivity, even without being able to program
- Make strategic decisions about integrating AI into existing business workflows
- Manage AI implementation challenges including data quality, validation of outcomes, and matching design choices to use cases
- How to move from simply "using AI" to being someone who "builds or manages AI tools"

Who Should Take This Course: This course is designed for *all MBA students* regardless of technical background. It's particularly valuable for those interested in:

- General management and strategic decision-making
- Product management and innovation
- Entrepreneurship, startups, and venture investing
- Operations and workflow optimization
- Organizational leadership and change management
- Consulting

Course Approach: Through case studies of successful AI implementations, hands-on exercises in designing AI workflows (no coding experience needed), and insights from industry leaders, you'll develop practical skills that go beyond simply using AI tools to strategically managing AI as a business resource.

By the end of this course, you'll be prepared to lead teams and organizations in evaluating, implementing, and optimizing AI-based systems that create competitive advantage.

Course Objectives

At the end of the course, students will be able to:

1. Identify business opportunities for AI applications and develop viable workflows.
2. Evaluate design choices and potential issues when deploying AI agents in real-world settings.
3. Build an AI chatbot that can do business tasks, including document retrieval and data analytics.

4. Apply non-technical/no-code AI Agent solutions to solve business problems.
5. Present AI system designs.

Course Materials

AI Setup

This course will require the active use of chatbots and LLM tools. Instead of requiring a textbook, I will ask you to subscribe to state-of-the-art chatbots for the duration of the class. Please check that you have access to the following tools before the beginning of class.

1. **State-of-the-art chatbots:** you need access to at least one chatbot with advanced reasoning capabilities. The exact choice of model is up to you, but I recommend **one** of the following:
    a. **OpenAI's ChatGPT:** subscribe to the paid Plus tier (or higher) for $20/month to access
    b. **Anthropic's Claude:** subscribe to the paid Pro tier (or higher) for $20/month to access the Opus reasoning models, and "extended thinking" mode.
2. **Chatbot building tools** you will need access to two no-code chatbot builder tools provided by OpenAI once you are on a paid plan.
    a. **OpenAI 'GPT':** subscribe to at least the Plus tier (or higher) to access the ability to build "GPTs" (chatbots) at https://chatgpt.com/gpts/editor. (for Assignment #1)
    b. **OpenAI Agent Builder:** Log in here to access the Agent Builder for Assignment #2: https://platform.openai.com/agent-builder.

    Set up Python: *This class requires no coding background.* However, for illustration purposes, we will want to explore "vibe-coding" with LLMs in class, and **you need an environment in which your AI is able to execute Python code** on your own laptop

UCLA's Anderbot: If you want to access a free chatbot with decent capabilities after the end of the class, you can explore UCLA's Anderbot, which is available with a UCLA ID through https://aoai.anderson.ucla.edu. It provides a workhorse chatbot powered by a recent small model (e.g. 4.1-mini) and also a reasoning model. For the reasoning model, go to Agents->View all Agents->Anderson-Reasoning. *However, during the class it is important that you have access to ChatGPT and Claude in the paid versions to see real-world capabilities.*

Readings

There is **no required textbook** in this class. The most up-to-date knowledge in this area is often distributed through X ('Twitter') or Substack.

Any required readings will be provided either as links or PDFs on the course site. You are expected to do the readings before class – they provide important context for class discussions.

We will also discuss the case "*Nurabot*" in one class, which was written by me for this course and will be provided as a free PDF.

Optional references – there is no required textbook, but I recommend the following as supplementary reading:

- Bornet et al. (2025), *Agentic Artificial Intelligence: Harnessing AI Agents to Reinvent Business, Work, and Life (ISBN - 979-8992833645)*
- Mollick, Ethan (2024), *Co-Intelligence: Living and Working with AI*
- Agrawal, Gans, Goldfarb (2022), *Power and Prediction: The Disruptive Economics of Artificial Intelligence*
- Narayanan & Kapoor (2024), *AI Snake Oil: What Artificial Intelligence Can Do, What It Can't, and How to Tell the Difference*
- Huyen, Chip (2024), *AI Engineering*
- Links and references to **optional readings** are posted on the Course Site.

Course Outline

Module/ Week	Date	Weekly Title & Key Topics	In-Class Activities	Pre-Class Reading	Assignments Due Before Class
1	April 1, 2026	• Recap of LLM Fundamentals • Developing AI Use Cases in Organizations	• In-class exercise: occupational task breakdown and AI potential for a job example	Required: • McKinsey, Exhibit, “There are many applications of generative AI across modalities” • Ethan Mollick (2024). "AI as a Coworker". Chapter 6 of *Co-Intelligence.* • Helen Toner, “Taking Jaggedness Seriously”, https://helentoner.substack.com/p/taking-jaggedness-seriously • Andy Jassy, “Message from CEO Andy Jassy: Some thoughts on Generative AI”, June 17, 2025 (https://www.aboutamazon.com/news/company-news/amazon-ceo-andy-jassy-on-generative-ai) Optional: • Timothy Lee, “Reinforcement learning, explained with a minimum of math and jargon”, https://www.understandingai.org/p/reinforcement-learning-explained • Meincke et al. “Prompting Diverse Ideas”. https://arxiv.org/pdf/2402.01727	• **Set up your LLM environment (see “AI Setup” section)**

Module/ Week	Date	Weekly Title & Key Topics	In-Class Activities	Pre-Class Reading	Assignments Due Before Class
2	April 8, 2026	• LLMs and Tool Use • Enhancing LLMs with Data using Retrieval-Augmented Generation	• In-class discussion of chatbot assignment	Required: • Casper, “Model intelligence is no longer the constraint for automation” https://latentintent.substack.com/p/model-intelligence-is-no-longer-the • Anthropic: Building Effective Agents. https://www.anthropic.com/engineering/building-effective-agents Optional: • Chapter 2 from Lanham (2025): “AI Agents in Action”	• **SUBMIT** Assignment: Build a chatbot using OpenAI GPTs
3	April 15, 2026	• Combining LLMs into AI Agent Workflows	• Claude Cowork exploration • Assignment recap and discussion • **Guest speaker: Andrew Smith Lewis, CEO & Founder of Alai Studios, https://www.alaistudios.com/about**	• Ferber et al. (2025) – “Development and validation of an autonomous artificial intelligence agent for clinical decision-making in oncology”. *Nature.* • Anthropic: Effective context engineering for AI agents. https://www.anthropic.com/engineering/effective-context-engineering-for-ai-agents • Anthropic: How we built our multi-agent research system. https://www.anthropic.com/engineering/built-multi-agent-research-system	• **SUBMIT** Assignment: Constructing a multi-step AI Agent workflow using no-code tools
4	April 22, 2026	• Reliability and Validation of AI Agents	• Case Discussion	• “*Nurabot: Agentic AI in Robotics*” Case • Anthropic, “Demystifying Evals For AI Agents”, https://www.anthropic.com/engineering/demystifying-evals-for-ai-agents	• **READ** *Nurabot* case and prepare questions for class discussion

Module/ Week	Date	Weekly Title & Key Topics	In-Class Activities	Pre-Class Reading	Assignments Due Before Class
5	April 29, 2026	• Competition and strategy for AI-focused organizations • Management challenges for AI-enabled organizations	• Student presentations • **Guest speaker: John Kennedy, CEO & Founder, Actual AI, https://www.actual.ai/about**	• Charlie Guo, "AI's Missing Multiplayer Mode" https://www.ignorance.ai/p/ais-missing-multiplayer-mode • Paul Graham. "Maker's schedule, manager's schedule". https://paulgraham.com/makersschedule.html • Ethan Mollick: "Making AI Work: Leadership, Lab, and Crowd". https://www.oneusefulthing.org/p/making-ai-work-leadership-lab-and	• **SUBMIT** Assignment: AI system design and minimum viable workflows • **PRESENT:** Student presentations of AI system designs and minimum viable workflows

Evaluation and Grading

Required Assignments and Weighted Percentages

This course will be graded using the following weighted percentages for each of the assignments in the course. Feedback and grades are typically posted within one week of assignment due dates.

Assignments	% of Grade
Participation and Engagement in Class and Case Discussions [Individual]	30%
Build a chatbot using OpenAI GPTs [Individual]	20%
Constructing a multi-step AI Agent workflow using no-code tools [Individual]	20%
Student presentations and write-up of AI system designs and minimum viable workflows [Individual]	30%
Total	**100%**

Grades

Your overall course grade will be determined by how your performance on graded assignments ranks in comparison with other students in the class according to the grade distribution model at Anderson. Note that courses in which an overall grade of C is received must be offset by higher grades in the same term for students to remain in good academic standing at UCLA.

Assignment Descriptions

Specific instructions, submission information, and any accompanying rubrics are detailed on the Course Site.

Participation and Engagement

Students are graded on both the quality and quantity of their contribution to class discussions. Students are expected to be able to contribute to discussions and answer questions regarding all required pre-class readings, as well as present and explain their submissions in response to assignments. To be precise:

- There is no credit for *attending* class, only for *participating* in class. However, you need to attend to participate.
- You will get credit for making at least one substantive comment in each given class – for up to 5 credits during the course (i.e. one per class)
- There is one additional credit for making a *substantial* contribution in at least one class during the term, which is defined as a sustained engagement and leadership in one discussion topic, or raising a new and well-substantiated idea or challenge, or volunteering for presenting something in front of the class.
- There are therefore up to 6 total participation credits
- Participation scores will be rescaled to align with the distribution of scores in other assignments before computing final grades
- You can make up for one class participation during the term (whether you actually attended or not) for a class where you did not receive participation credit by sending me a short write-up (1-2 pages) with your thoughts and personal reflections on some of the topics discussed during class (for which you will need to review the video recording that is made available online after class).

Anderson and Course Policies

AI Usage Policy

This course will allow the use of AI (Large Language Models, including ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini, and others) to enhance your learning, not replace it! The goal is to expand student capabilities and output in research and analysis, providing greater time to contemplate, analyze, and develop more sophisticated analyses, recommendations, and leadership imperatives

You are encouraged to use AI tools in any way that improves your work and understanding of the material. However, you will be fully responsible for the output and for explaining the output that you submit.

Netiquette

The written language has many advantages: more opportunity for reasoned thought, more ability to go in-depth, and more time to think through an issue before posting a comment. However, written communication also has certain disadvantages, such a lack of the face-to-face signaling that occurs through body language, intonation, pausing, facial expressions, and gestures. As a result, please be aware of the possibility of miscommunication and compose your comments in a positive, supportive, and constructive manner.

UCLA Policies

Code of Conduct

All participants in the course are bound by the **UCLA Student Conduct Code** (https://deanofstudents.ucla.edu/individual-student-code) and **UCLA Anderson Honor Code** (https://www.anderson.ucla.edu/documents/areas/adm/web/AndersonHonorCode.pdf).

Academic Integrity

UCLA is an institution of learning, research, and scholarship predicated on the existence of an environment of honesty and integrity. As members of the academic community, instructors, students, and administrative officials are all responsible for maintaining this environment. It is essential that all members of the academic community practice academic honesty and integrity and accept individual responsibility for their work. Academic misconduct is unacceptable and will not be tolerated in this course. Cheating, forgery, dishonest conduct, plagiarism, and collusion in academic misconduct erode the University's educational, research, and social roles.

Students who knowingly or intentionally conduct or help another student engage in acts that violate UCLA's expectations of academic integrity will be subject to disciplinary action and referred to the Dean of Students' Office.

Please familiarize yourself with **UCLA's Academic Integrity Policy:** https://www.deanofstudents.ucla.edu/Academic-Integrity. Speak to your instructor if you have any questions about what is and is not allowed in this course.

Integrity in Research

Integrity in research includes not just the avoidance of wrongdoing, but also the rigor, carefulness, and accountability that are hallmarks of good scholarship. All persons engaged in research at the University are responsible for adhering to the highest standards of intellectual honesty and integrity in research.

Please familiarize yourself with the **University of California Policy on Integrity in Research** (https://www.ucop.edu/academic-personnel-programs/_files/apm/apm-190-b.pdf)

Accessible Education & Inclusive Education

Disability Services

UCLA is committed to providing a barrier-free environment for persons with documented disabilities. If you are already registered with the Center for Accessible Education (CAE), please request your Letter of Accommodation in the Student Portal. If you are seeking registration with the CAE, please submit your request for accommodation via the CAE website. Students with disabilities requiring academic accommodations should submit their request for accommodations as soon as possible, as it may take up to two weeks to review the request. For more information, please visit the CAE website (www.cae.ucla.edu), visit the CAE at A255 Murphy Hall, contact CAE by phone at (310) 825-1501, or by telecommunication device for the deaf at (310) 206-6083.

Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion

Please familiarize yourself with UCLA Anderson's commitment to maintaining an equitable, diverse, and inclusive community:
(https://www.anderson.ucla.edu/about/equity-diversity-and-inclusion)